

TELL ME HOW TO BE
by Neel Patel
HAMISH HAMILTON
₹599; 336 pages



BOOKS

ALL IN THE FAMILY

NEEL PATEL'S DEBUT NOVEL HAS ALL THE NOSTALGIA OF DIASPORIC FICTION AND THE ANGST OF A FAMILY MELODRAMA

Over the years, authors such as Jhumpa Lahiri, Chitra Banerjee and Anita Desai, among many others, have brought the Indian diasporic experience to the forefront. Women plucked from the heart of India and placed in an unfamiliar American city, men travelling to another country to study or work, brown children growing up alongside white classmates—these are often some of the characters diasporic fiction is littered with. Nostalgia and longing are the lifeblood of the genre. Some have done it well, while others have followed a tired pattern—detailed descriptions of samosas and aromatic lamb curries, of romantic loves left behind, of meddlesome 'uncles' and 'aunties'.

Neel Patel's *Tell Me How to Be* falls somewhere in the middle. It has some of the cliched tropes, but its protagonists set it apart ever so slightly. The story is told from the point of view of two characters—Renu and her son Akash. Renu is sharp-tongued, seemingly closed-minded and mostly unlikeable, while Akash is a pitiable, closeted man who grew up in the shadow of his perfect elder brother Bijal and is now battling alcoholism. Both mother and son live with heavy secrets. They both crave absolution.

Renu, an Indian, grew up in Tanzania. She studied in London and came to the US after marriage, leaving behind her first love, Kareem, a Muslim man. Patel traces the root of her anger and bitterness towards her husband and the life he has given her, which, to an outsider, would seem picture perfect. Akash, on the other hand, has escaped the conservative surroundings of home, moving to LA to become a music composer. He is, however, unable to utter to his family the three words he wants to say most: "I am gay." Just like Renu, Akash too has been unable to let go of his first and only love, Parth.

Patel's writing tends to be repetitive, his metaphors unimaginative—at one point he mentions the steam rising from a cup of tea twice within 100 words. Patel makes use of flashbacks to unfurl past traumas that have made Renu and Akash who they are, but though he gives both characters equal space in the book, it's Renu who is far more complex and compelling. She has made a place for herself in a country that either outright rejects Indians or exoticises them. She knows not to engage too much with the young American woman asking her opinion on a brand of frozen *malai kofta* in the supermarket, and how to smile and give a vague answer to her book club members when asked for "her perspective". Importantly, she knows how to bite back the words always forming in her mouth—"white bitch!". But mostly, it is her relationship with her husband, whose death has brought on feelings of great grief and guilt that finally draw a reader in.

Tell Me... is a perfectly average novel about the Indian experience in the US, of racism, bullying, homophobia. But at the heart of it, *Tell Me...* is a family drama. It's about finding your way back to your mother, brother, father, proving that despite everything, blood is thicker than water. ■

–Zinnia Ray Chaudhuri

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